Hearts of My Heart

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Hearts of My Heart

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Summary

Magicats fall in love like everyone else except for when they don't.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Catra's Rooms

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Eight Years After the Coup Attempt

"Catra! Are you ready yet?" Adora called out from where she's currently sitting on one of the chairs in Catra's living room. It was currently the day of their weekly shopping trip and Adora was idly swinging her legs back and forth as she eagerly waited for her best friend to finish getting ready.

"Almost! Just give me one more minute!" Catra called back from inside her bedroom with a giggle. "I swear, we've done this for how long now? And you're *always* this way!"

"That's because you're always so slow!" Adora shoots back. "I wear more jewelry than you do and yet I can get ready in half the time!"

"That's because you also wear less *clothes* than I do," Catra replied as she exited her bedroom.

Adora looked down at what she was wearing. It was fairly simple as far as cave culture outfits went: a white chestwrap over which she wore silver bolero shrug patterned with stars and diamonds. She was also wearing white compression shorts that went down to her mid-thigh to go along with a silver half-skirt trimmed with gold. The half-skirt was held up by a silver chain belt from which her *kiari* was sheathed. On her feet were silver, soft-soled moccasins that had been made for her by one of her cave culture friends.

For accessories, she was wearing six ear piercings—three on each ear—that were a combination of small hoops and studs (but no gauges, large hoops, or anything that could be easy to grab in a fight) as well as a gold-colored silk choker and silver filigree cuffs on either arm.

"Hey, it's not *my* fault that you being the Crown Princess means that you can't wear cave culture clothes," Adora said as she stood up.

"Yeah, yeah. Now, c'mon, let's—" Catra started to reach for Adora's hand only to stop when the door to her rooms suddenly busted open.

"C'y! 'Dora!" Little Caspin cried out. "Let's go to the park!" They quickly rushed over to stand between the two of them, looking back and forth between them with his best pleading expression.

Adora and Catra shared a look before the latter said, "Caspin, Adora and I—"

"But you two go shopping *every week!"* Caspin cut her off again.

"And we play with *you* nearly every day," Adora pointed out.

"So?" Caspin had the look of someone who had just been told that water was wet.

Adora and Catra shared another look, both of them clearly (to each other) struggling not to laugh.

"Fair enough," Catra relented as she held out her hand toward the Princeps. "C'mon, let's go to the park."

Caspin took her hand and started tugging her out the door. "YAY! Let's go, let's go!"

One of the Parks

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Eight Years After the Coup Attempt

There were, surprisingly, quite a few parks in Halfmoon despite being located far beneath the surface. They were basically the only places in the entire kingdom (other than the "secret" caves where Halfmoon got all of its wood from) where one could go to actually see grass and trees along with flowers from the surface, all maintained through carefully applied spells.

They were, naturally, *very* popular spots for all kinds of activities, not the least of which was bringing kittens to play and hopefully burn off some of their energy.

Thankfully for Caspin (and for Catra and Adora), their two big sisters were plenty energetic in their own right.

"Tag! You're it!" Caspin cried out as Catra let him tag her. Catra immediately skidded to a stop and turned around to give chase to her little sibling.

"Come back here you little rascal!" Catra shouted as she ran. Caspin actually wasn't the easiest person in the world to keep up with thanks to the fact that, still being a kitten, they were completely without shame and were more than willing to run on all fours when excited. Thankfully, Catra and Adora and were just really fast in their own right.

"Watch out, Caspin! She's right behind you!" Adora called out from where she stood off to the side, triggering a delighted shriek from Caspin. While both of them *were* playing with Caspin, they would largely only chase him when tagged unless otherwise told to and he would switch whoever he was chasing after once tagged. They'd also swap out if the chase ever led them to each other.

As Adora watched on with a soft smile on her face, she nodded at the person who passed by her on their way deeper into the park. She then realized that Caspin's path was going to make them run headfirst into the stranger so she started to call out a warning only to stop when she saw the unmistakable glint of metal in the stranger's hand.

"CASPIN, RUN BACK TO CATRA!" Adora called out as she drew her *kiari* and started to move at the same time that the assassin started to sprint toward the Princeps.

Seeing that she wasn't going to be able to make it in time, Adora called upon her magic to give herself increased alacrity. However, it immediately became apparent that, even *with* that boost, she wouldn't make it in time.

But Catra would. "CASPIN!" she called out as she threw herself between her little sibling at the assassin. The assassin's blade shot forth and was buried inside Catra's stomach before a twisting jerk caused it to slice through her.

"CATRA!" Adora cried as she watched her best friend collapse to the ground like a puppet with its strings cut as the assassin started running away. Adora slid the last foot or so on her knees once she reached her. She set her *kiari* down and reached out to grab the petrified Caspin before pulling them behind her. "Stay there, Caspin, and hold on to me!" she ordered, spurring the kitten into action.

All around them, the people in the park that had been nearby were shouting and screaming but Adora paid them no mind. She didn't even pay that much attention to Caspin once he had started clinging to her to her back, their claws digging slightly into her skin. Instead, all of Adora's attention was focused on Catra as she placed one of hands on the wound to try and stop the bleeding.

Then Adora remembered that there was someone else who deserved her attention, if only for a moment: the assassin.

Adora glared at the retreating form of the assassin, her eyes as cold as ice. She *needed* to kill that person, that monster, that *thing* but she couldn't leave Catra and Caspin. She needed to stay near them in case there were more assassins and she needed to heal Catra as soon as possible. She didn't have the *time* to chase them down.

… But Adora didn't *have* to chase them down to kill them. Sure, if she wanted to give them an honorable death where they faced her in single combat then, yes, she would, but she didn't *want* to give them an honorable death, she just wanted them *dead.*

Adora raised her right hand and pointed one finger at the fleeing Magicat. Her eyes burned an electric blue as gold shined underneath her skin and arced through her glowing hair. She called upon her celestial magics and drew that gold down into the point of her index finger, compressing it more and more until the spell was about to burst.

With pinpoint precision, Adora aimed and fired. A beam of molten gold shot from her fingertip at impossible speeds to punch a hole almost half the size of Adora's fist clean through their heart before harmlessly dissipating mere feet in front of them.

Adora watched the assassin's body fall for one moment, two, three, before letting her focus be snapped back to where Catra was currently bleeding out in front of her.

"Hold on, Catra! I've got you! Just hang in there" Adora cried as her body and eyes started to glow ever brighter. All around her, people were still shouting and running but she paid them no mind. The only people she could acknowledge right now were Catra and—

"Is C'y gonna be okay, 'Dora?" a crying Caspin asked as he shifted to cling to Adora's arm.

Adora quickly spared them a glance and tried to smile but she knew that she failed. “She’s going to be just fine,” she said to both them and herself as her golden light started to enveloped Catra. “She just needs to hang on a little longer and—” Adora was startled as a new voice approached.

“I’m with the City Watch!” they said. “Let me help—”

Their words were cut off as Adora’s head snapped up to glare bloody murder at them. Her eyes were impossibly blue and as hard as diamonds while her hair looked more like a lion’s mane from the way it fell about her shoulders.

“STAY BACK!” Adora *roared.* Golden power shot out from her to form a dome of pale translucence that surrounded the three of them and kept everyone else out. The member of the City Watch flinched as if struck and took several steps back.

“A… dora…” Catra’s weak voice made Adora’s attention snap back to her once more.

“I’m here, Catra, I’m here!” she said, a hint of desperation in her voice as she returned to pouring as much of her healing magic into Catra as she could.

“It… hurts…” Catra said, the words nearly driving Adora to tears.

“Shhh, it’s okay, Catra. I know it hurts but everything’s going to be just fine!” Adora replied as she pressed her forehead to Catra’s and closed her eyes even as she started pseudo-purring to try and comfort her best friend. She felt more than she heard Caspin’s purr rise to meet hers a moment later.

Adora’s not sure how long she stayed that way but she didn’t *care.* The only thing she cared about was making sure that the person she cared for the most in this life survived. To that end, even when Catra’s breathing evened out into a normal sleep, she didn’t stop the flood of healing magic, wanting to make sure not even the tiniest scrape remained on her.

After an unknown eternity passed, two blessedly familiar voices cut through Adora's total concentration.

"ADORA!"

"LITTLE LION!"

"MAMA! PAPA!" Caspin said as he detached himself from Adora's arm.

Adora pulled back and blinked the stars out of her eyes as she dropped her shield just in time to let Caspin run past and into Lyra's arms.

"How is C'yara?" a panicked Tiger asked as he ran up to them, dropped down on his knees on the other side of Catra. His eyes carefully but quickly scanned his daughter for any trace of injury even as his eyes widened almost imperceptibly at the sight of all of the blood.

"She's gonna be fine," Adora answered as she started to let her light recede. "I got to her in time. It was," she swallowed, "it was close but I got to her in time."

Satisfied that his daughter was no longer injured, Tiger looked up at Adora and gave her a haggard yet gracious smile. "That you did, Little Lion." He glanced over at the corpse of the assassin. "And you got the one who did it, too. Were there any others?"

"No, just the one," Adora said as she fully pulled her light back and let her magic start to fade. "They tried to ki— to get Caspin when… when…"

As Adora's magic fully receded, a wave of vertigo hit her like a runaway skiff. The world was spinning around her and she was faintly aware of Tiger and Lyra calling her name but they sounded like they were far away.

And then the ground rushed up to meet Adora's face and she knew no more.

The Infirmary

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Eight Years After the Coup Attempt

Adora groaned as she returned to consciousness. Her entire body vaguely ached and she felt like she could sleep for a week straight, so, as far as she was concerned, she was perfectly fine.

"Hey, you. You're finally awake," a familiar voice said. Hearing it made Adora wince not because of who the voice belonged to but because he was so *loud.* She tried to open her eyes to look around only to have to immediately shut them again. Since when did Halfmoon become *Bright* Moon?

"Everything alright there, Adora?" Lenio asked, concern coloring his voice. Adora tried to take a deep breath through her nose to center herself only to stop short and nearly cough as she was suddenly hit by the overpowering stench of antiseptic.

Slowly but surely, Adora managed to open her eyes enough to see Lenio's worried expression. "It's *really* bright, you're *super* loud, and it smells like someone dipped my nose into an antiseptic," Adora all but whispered.

Lenio's worried expression was now almost completely replaced by confusion. "*Really* now? One moment." He muttered a few spells and Adora could suddenly breathe easier as the smell was cleared away. He then dimmed the lights which let Adora fully open her eyes. "How's that? Any better?" he asked quietly.

Adora let out a sigh of relief. "*Much* better." She was just about to settle back into the bed when her mind finally caught up to her

situation. "Where's Catra? Is she alright?" she asked, suddenly panicking as she bolted upright.

Lenio had the gall to actually *snicker* at her abrupt change of mood. "C'yara is quite alright; you did an excellent job healing her. She won't even have a scar," he reassured her.

Adora let out an even bigger sigh of relief as she collapsed backward onto the bed. "Thank the Stars Above *and* the Fires Below. And Caspin? How's he doing?"

"The young Princeps was more than a little shaken up. He'll be seeing a councillor for a while to try and help them deal with it. *Hopefully,* the poor kid just walks away with some bad memories and the odd nightmare for a few months and doesn't develop anything permanent."

Adora nodded. "Yeah, we can only pray," she said somewhat distantly as her mind flashed back to all of the horrors she experienced during those first couple years of her life that she could remember. Adora was *more* than fine, if you asked her—the past eight years have been a sweeter dream than any that she had ever had back in the Horde—but she'd still rather let Caspin avoid as much of it as possible.

"How long was I out for, anyway?"

Lenio checked the clock. "A bit over eighteen hours."

"Eighteen hours?" Adora parroted incredulously. "What happened to *me?"*

"It appears to be some variant of acute magical exhaustion," Lenio answered. "You poured a *lot* of magic into C'yara to heal her wounds and then some on top of erecting what was no doubt an extremely powerful barrier and whatever it was you did to that would-be assassin. It's little wonder that you passed out, frankly."

Adora sighed as she closed her eyes and pinched the bridge of her nose. The great thing about her magic was that she never

seemed to get tired while using it. The *bad* thing about her magic was that all of the fatigue she'd otherwise normally feel hits her all at once as soon as she stopped using it.

"Where *is* Catra, anyway?" Adora asked with a tilt of her head. "It smells like she was in here not too long ago." Now that the scent of disinfectant was no longer overpowering her, she could distinctly smell a scent that she could only describe as Catra. It was faint, though.

"Oh, really, now?" Lenio asked with a knowing smile and a twinkle in his eye. "C'yara was last here about fourteen hours ago. She *wanted* to stay by your side but you were perfectly healthy, she had a number of duties that she needed to attend to, and she needed to rest in someplace far more comfortable in the infirmary. Even then, I only managed to get her to leave by promising to not go anywhere unless it was an emergency."

Adora frowned at that. "If that's true then why does it smell like she was in here an hour ago at most?" Come to think of it, how could she smell Catra's scent so clearly in the first place? She could normally only smell it if she had her nose pressed up against her hair or fur.

Lenio's smile only grew. "How indeed. Tell me, what do you know about how we Magicats fall in love?"

"You guys do it like everyone el—" Adora cut herself off as the pieces clicked into place, her eyes becoming as wide as saucers. "No way. But I'm not a Magicat." For some reason, those words left a bitter feeling in Adora's heart but she pushed it down and locked it away.

"True," Lenio allowed with a nod, "but that doesn't matter. Even if we didn't have the evidence right in front of us, I've seen plenty of Magicats imprint on non-Magicats and they all went through a similar process of gaining heightened senses and all of the other fun stuff that comes along with imprinting. In fact, I even have some literature on it tucked away somewhere."

"But I didn't even know that I was in love with Catra!" Adora tried to refute. Even to her own ears, that "defense" was weaker than Kyle (she prayed that he was okay).

Lenio's smile became downright smug. "Oh, you most certainly were. Just ask anyone who's know the two of you for more than, oh, ten minutes and they'll agree with me. In fact, Cyrus and I had a bet going on as to when you two would finally imprint; a bet that I won, by the way. Cyrus is many things but a good gambler is *not* one of— Is that a mouse?" Lenio suddenly said excitedly as he pointed to the other side of Adora.

"A mouse? Where?" Adora shouted, her fingers splayed and her eyes wide and sparkling with excitement as she quickly hopped to her feet and turned to face in the direction that Lenio was pointing.

Only to suddenly *stop* when she realized what she had just done and when Lenio started laughing uproariously, the loudness of the sound coupled with the embarrassment caused her to pin her shoulders back.

"See? What did I tell you?" Lenio asked through his laughter. "That was *exactly* the same reaction that C'yara has. As does Cyrus, for that matter." He paused as a thought occurred to him. "I wonder if Lyra… Hm…" he mumbled before shaking his head.

Seeing as how she was already standing, Adora stepped down off of the bed and sat at the edge of it facing Lenio. Taking stock of herself, she saw that she was now wearing a plain, loose t-shirt and equally plain shorts and also that she was no longer wearing any of her jewelry. She recognized the clothes as being ones that she occasionally wore when sleeping so she wondered if Kesi or Kelara had come by both to drop those off and also take her jewelry. Maybe both of them?

"So, what do I do about—" Adora was cut off by the sound of the door being slammed open followed by an absolutely beautiful voice.

"ADORA!" Catra screamed as she raced over and all but threw herself at Adora, crawling across the bed so that way she could crawl into her lap.

Adora was vaguely aware of Lenio leaving as Catra started to aggressively scent mark her as she purred up a storm. She always enjoyed having Catra in her arms and listening to/feeling her purr but the heightened every caused by their imprint made it even better. Those things coupled with Catra's extremely comforting scent let Adora slip into a relaxed state that she can't recall ever having been in before.

"Hey, Catra," Adora said softly as she wrapped her arms around her best friend. (Imprinted partner? What was the word in *Aiilayra* for that? Adora couldn't remember.) "How are you feeling?"

"Better, now that you're awake," Catra answered. She seemed to finally think that Adora smelled enough like her now because she stopped scent marking her and instead buried her face in the crook of her shoulder, her nose near Adora's pulse point.

"Don't scare me like that," Catra reprimanded her, her voice small.

Adora squeezed Catra a bit tighter. *"I'm* the one who should be saying that to *you,"* she countered. "How'd you know that I was awake?"

Catra gave her a reprimanding nip. "Lenio sent me a message the moment you woke up. It just took me a while to be able to get here," she answered.

The two of them lapsed into relative silence after that, the only sounds filling the air being their purring. Despite the atmosphere being so comfortable that Adora was debating pulling Catra down onto the bed with her to take a nap, Catra broke it by speaking up.

"Promise me you won't do that again," Catra asked, her voice so quiet that Adora could only just barely hear it.

Adora let out a slow, steady breath. "I can't do that, Catra," she said. "You *know* that I'm training to become your Appointed Knight. It'll be my entire job to make sure that you're safe no matter what and it's a job that I'll do gladly.

"You've given me *so much,* Catra. You and Tiger and Lyra and Kelara and Kesi and Caspin. You've given me a life better than anything I could have ever imagined and I am going to do *everything* I can to make sure nothing truly bad happens. So long as you're with me, everything will be alright."

Catra pulled back slightly to stare into Adora's eyes. "You promise?"

Adora smiled lovingly at her. "I promise."

Kesi's Old Room

Kesi's Parents' House

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Ten Years After the Coup Attempt

Adora paced back and forth across Kesi's old room as she tried and failed to fight off a low growl, her fists clenching and unclenching with the desire to hit something, to hit *someone.*

"You don't have to do this, Adora," Kesi said quietly to the girl from where she sat curled up on her bed, her knees tucked under her chin. Kesi's ears were pinned back and her tail was held firmly in her hands to stop it from lashing.

"Yes, Kesi, I do," Adora contradicted, speaking in nearly flawless *Aiilayra.* "Enough is *too much!* They *can't* keep getting away with this!"

The reason for Adora's presence was to stage a sort of intervention. Kesi's parents and grandfather haven't always been the nicest people towards Kesi (at least not as far as Adora knows) but their behavior had slowly deteriorated. Kesi had recently been appointed Catra's Seneschal and thus, by extension, one of the most powerful people in all of Halfmoon. Adora knew now that good parents would have been happy and excited for Kesi (in fact, Kelara *had* been those things) and yet her parents and grandfather *hadn't.*

If it had simply been that, well, it wouldn't have been *good* but it wouldn't warrant what was about to happen. No, instead, they seemed to become *angrier* at her for it. As things currently were, Kesi's mother, Timara Tr'irel, would only speak to her daughter when she visited home once a month and that was only to shout at her. Her father, Mardan Ir'edel, wasn't nearly as bad, admittedly, but he was still bad.

And as for Hethrir, Kesi's maternal grandfather? Well, *he* was the reason that Kesi didn't have the surname "Tr'irel" despite the fact that she *should.* That alone was a damnable offense, as far as Adora was concerned, but he also seemed to try his level best to simply pretend that she didn't even *exist.*

What had *finally* spurred Adora into action had been what had happened late yesterday evening. Adora had finished up some light exercise and was sitting down to practice her cartography (a hobby she picked up a bit under a year ago) when Kesi had suddenly burst into her room. The other girl had been borderline inconsolable with her crying as she had all but thrown herself into Adora's lap.

Adora had almost immediately started pseudo-purring as she used just a bit of her magic to allow herself to effortlessly lift the older girl up and carry her over to sit down at the edge of her

bed. Adora then went about trying her best to soothe her best friend after she had gotten herself settled by burying her face in the cook of her neck, her nose pressed up against Adora's pulse point, while her tail wrapped around one of Adora's arms.

Adora had kept up her pseudo-purr while her free hand went up to pet Kesi's ears and her other hand had slowly stroked up and down her spine, giving her scratches on the way up before petting her fur flat on the way back down. It had taken a couple minutes but, eventually, Kesi had calmed down enough to tell Adora what had happened.

And the answer had *infuriated* her.

"Your parents said that you're wasting your time with me and that you should forget me and Catra and your faith and just be a tailor! They're trying to restrict who you are, Kesi, who you choose to be! And don't even get me *started* on Hethrir!"

Adora took a deep breath to try and calm herself down. It worked a little bit. "Kesi," she began, her voice gentle and almost a whisper, "do you remember when I was six and you asked me who I wanted to be?"

Kesi nodded, a ghost of a smile crossing her face as she recalled that day. "You said that you wanted to be able to protect the people you care about, people like me and Catra.

Adora smiled at her as she stepped closer to her and began to scratch at the base of one of her ears. Kesi's eyes closed as she nuzzled up into the affection and started to lightly purr, her tail slipping out of her hand to wrap around Adora's wrist. "That's right. I've had to watch your relationship with your parents deteriorate, watch you come back from talking to them upset and frustrated, for too long. So, I'm going to be who I choose to be and protect you as best I can. Will you let me?"

Kesi opened her eyes and stared into Adora's for a long moment before she slowly nodded. "Yeah. I'll let you," she said

with a soft smile that Adora gladly returned.

"Great!" Adora said, dropping her hand and ignoring how Kesi's pout tugged at her heart. "Let's get going."

The Dining Room

Kesi's Parents' House

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Ten Years After the Coup Attempt

Adora strode into the dining room with Kesi following right behind. Despite the rage boiling inside her chest, she kept her pace controlled, her gait loose, and her expression neutral. She knew that she was going into this confrontation from a lesser position due to her young age and so she needed to act as calmly and maturely as possible. She needed to act like Queen Lyra when she was holding court. She had even worn some of her more formal clothes.

Though it wasn't intended or even conscious at this point, her *kiari* that hung by her belt helped serve as a reminder of what she was and what she could do.

Kesi's parents, Hethrir, and Kelara (who didn't need to be here, strictly speaking, but was anyway) were all seated at the dining room table. They had been talking amongst themselves until Adora and Kesi entered the room which caused them to give Adora their undivided attention.

"Good. You're all here," Adora began as she stood on the opposite side of the table from everyone in a neutral stance with her hands clasped behind her back. "That means that we can get down to business immediately."

"And what, exactly, *is* this business, Adora?" Timara asked somewhat tersely. Timara was a short and stocky woman—almost as short as Catra—with dark grey fur and pale grey stripes and markings.

Adora ignored her tone and almost ignored her words entirely. She knew what she needed to say and she knew how she needed to say it. She wouldn't let them get her off track.

"I've asked you all to be here for one *very* simple reason: three of you," her gaze lingered on Mardan, Tamara, and Hethrir, "have been treating Kesi very poorly for a long time now and I'm *sick* of it."

"The way we treat our daughter is none of your concern, Adora," Tamara interjected.

"Oh, but it absolutely is," Adora countered, staring Tamara down with unblinking eyes. She slightly rolled her right shoulder which everyone but Hethrir knew was a stand-in for her ear twitching. "Kesi is my best friend and has been there for me ever since the day I arrived in Halfmoon. She helped make my room at the High Temple be *my* room, she taught me how to use eating utensils correctly, she helped me figure out how to pronounce *Aiilayra* as accurately as possible, she's helped me figure out who I am and how to be me.

"Kesi means the *world* to me and how you treat her is my business. *Especially* since the kind of person I am is someone who can and *will* stand up for those they care about. And that's exactly what I'm doing right now because *no one* means more to me than Kesi does." Adora found that last statement to be surprising—it wasn't something that she had planned on saying—but it was also *true.* Even though she was imprinted with Catra, Kesi meant just as much to her as Catra did.

Behind her, almost too faint for her to hear despite her hearing having *vastly* improved since imprinting with Catra, Adora could just *barely* make out the sound of Kesi's pleased purr. The sound

banked the flames of Adora's growing passionate ire and let her remain calm.

Silence hung in the air for a long moment as everyone absorbed what Adora had just said. Tamara and Mardan both looked contemplative while Hethrir's expression was blank and Kelara was smiling warmly at the two of them, a curious twinkle in her eyes.

Mardan—who was a tall, almost unhealthily skinny man with pale grey fur and black markings—was the one to break the silence. "You really care about our daughter," he said more than asked as he looked at Adora as though seeing her for the first time. It almost made Adora want to squirm but she stayed still.

"I do," Adora replied with a nod before turning her attention back to Tamara. "Now, please, don't think of me as ungrateful. I *really* appreciate you learning how to work leather in order to make me boots during those early years, Tamara," Adora blinked her thanks and Tamara smiled slightly as she blinked back, "it's just that I can't just do nothing and wait for Kesi to come to me in tears again because of words you've said to her."

Tamara and Mardan both looked slightly stricken at that, which gladdened Adora. Whatever was going on, they didn't seem to *hate* their daughter. Which just left the matter of… "What problem do you even have with her? If she did something to upset you other than be who she wants to be then just say so and I *know* that she'll apologise and try to make it up to you." Adora turned slightly to look at Kesi. "Right?"

"Of course I will!" Kesi replied immediately with a violent nod of her head. She opened her mouth as if to say more but then closed it as she looked back at Adora. She was clearly holding back to let Adora handle the situation which is something that Adora appreciated greatly given how much planning she had put into this. She smiled and slowly blinked at her, a gesture that she returned.

Adora looked back at the others in time to catch Tamara sharing a quick look with Mardan before looking down into her lap. While Adora couldn't tell for certain, she would be willing to bet good money that she was fiddling with either her hands or her husband's tail.

"It's nothing specific that she's done, it's just," Tamara cut herself off with a sigh. "I worry about her, okay? She's my daughter and, despite how it may seem, I *do* love her. I'm just… worried. The only reason you're here is because of a coup attempt that killed off most of the royal family, you know? I'd feel *much* better if she stayed out of everything and was just a tailor but," she sighed again, "I can see now that that won't be happening." She looked up and into Adora's eyes. Her gaze was somehow both challenging and pleading. "Kesi did right by helping you and becoming your friend. You're a good person, Adora.

"And, Kesi," she turned to face her daughter, "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have told you that you were wasting your time by being friends with Adora or being Princess C'yara's Seneschal. That was out of line. I'm still worried—I'll *always* worry—but I trust Adora to keep you safe."

A teary-eyed Kesi quickly ran around the table to meet her rising parents in a fierce hug. Adora understood being afraid like that, probably better than most people would think. She had wanted to train to become strong in order to protect the people that she cared about because she was afraid of losing them and that fear had not gone away since. If anything, it was *greater* since she almost lost Catra two years ago. To this day, she was terrified that she would wake up one day and be back in the Fright Zone with all of her time in Halfmoon having been an elaborate fever dream.

Even so, Adora didn't let that fear rule her. She let it motivate her to become the best swordswoman and sorceress that she possibly could be. While she couldn't do anything about her fear of this all being an elaborate dream, she *could* ensure that anyone

who tries to take one of her precious people away will regret every choice that they had ever made.

After a few more moments, Kesi sniffed before pulling away from her parents and wiping at her eyes. She then smiled at them before returning to her previous position which was just to Adora's right and three paces behind. (Now that she thought about it, that's where she stood when acting as Catra's Seneschal, too.)

Adora had a feeling that whatever was going on hadn't been resolved, not really, and a quick visual check in with Kesi showed that the other likely felt the same way. Still, this was a start and Adora was more than willing to work with it.

After letting the silence linger just a moment longer, Adora then turned her attention to the one person who had said nothing thus far but who absolutely *should* have.

"What about you, Hethrir?" she asked. "What has Kesi done to upset you?"

"That, child, does not concern you irregardless of what you say," Hethrir drawled and Adora had to fight down the urge to punch him right in his prick face (seriously, she had *never* seen someone with a more punchable face before in her *life).*

While Adora wouldn't punch him, she *wasn't* above intimidation tactics. "You know what? Fine. However," she called upon just a sliver of her vast well of celestial magics causing her eyes to blaze electric blue while gold burned under her skin and through her hair, "just remember that Kesi is under *my* protection and I will not tolerate anyone hurting her."

Hethrir went still as a statue and Adora couldn't read even the slightest bit of emotion off of him. "I do not appreciate being threatened, child," he said, his voice as cold as ice.

Adora let her power recede. "I'm not threatening you, I was just making my stance clear. If you have no intention of hurting her then we don't have a problem."

"Hm. Indeed. Are we quite through here?"

Adora first looked at Kelara, who nodded, and then at Kesi, who also nodded. "Yeah. We're through."

Adora's Room

The High Temple

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Ten Years After the Coup Attempt

Adora all but collapsed onto her bed after she had set her *kiari* on its wall mount while Kesi giggled and sat down on the edge with much more grace. Adora had gone into that confrontation expecting it to be a *lot* but it was somehow *even more* draining than what she had expected. It was well worth the results, though.

She *really* wanted to slip out of her more formal clothes and into something casual like she'd usually wear but there was something a bit more important that needed to be addressed first.

"So," Adora began as she turned her head to look at Kesi, "what does that mean for us?" She knew that she didn't need to clarify what she was talking about. Not that long ago, Adora had said that no one was more important to her despite the fact that she's imprinted with Catra. As such, that could only mean one thing:

Kesi had imprinted with her.

Kesi laid down next to Adora with another giggle, the sound causing Adora's heart to do funny things. "Right now, it doesn't mean much of anything," Kesi said.

Adora frowned at that. “Why not?”

Kesi let out a fond yet exasperated sigh. “Because *you* are still a minor whereas *I* am not. It’s not like with you and Catra where you’re both about the same age.”

Adora looked off to the side and grumbled about “stupid magic number theory” only for her grumblings to cease and her face to scrunch up as Kesi booped her in the nose with her tail.

“Yes, yes. Your opinions on needing to be a certain age in order to do certain things are well known, Adora.” As Kesi was talking, she jerked her tail back when Adora tried to swat at it. “Hey, look at it this way: you said that you were going to protect me and now it’ll be a *lot* easier since you’ll basically always be able to find me.”

“Yeah, true,” Adora allowed with an explosive sigh. After a moment, she scowled and sat up long enough to take off her formal top and throw it onto the back of her desk chair and kick off her shoes that one of her cave culture friends made before collapsing again.

“I *really* don’t get how Catra and her family can stand being covered up so much all the time. And I don’t even have fur!” Adora said, throwing her arms up with the last statement.

Kesi laughed. “Spoken like a true cave girl! I honestly don’t really get it, either, and am just thankful that Catra lets me wear basically fancy versions of cave culture clothes when I’m on the clock.” Kesi tended to be on the clock more often than not but yesterday had been one of her days off and Catra had decided to give her today off, too, after Adora told her what went down.

The two laid in companionable silence for a long while before Adora yawned. “Well,” she said around her yawn, “I don’t know about you but I’m *beat.* I swear, these big emotions things take more out of me than even the harshest training.”

"That's because you don't exercise your big emotions muscles enough!" Kesi teased. But, yeah, I'm pretty drained, too."

"Nap time?" Adora asked.

"Nap time," Kesi confirmed as she got up.

Adora got up as well and quickly took off her formal pants as she went to her closet, grabbing her shoes and shirt along the way. She made sure that her shirt and pants were properly hung up and relatively wrinkle free before grabbing a pair of plain, white shorts that she liked to sleep in. She didn't bother grabbing a top and just stuck with her chestwrap.

By the time she was finished with that and in her shorts, Kesi was already gone but that didn't bother Adora any. Instead, she went over to her jewelry box and went through the careful process of removing her piercing (she now had three on each ear, one on her left eyebrow, and one on the right-hand side of her nose).

(She *wanted* to also get her belly button pierced but Magic Number Theory struck again as she needed to be at least sixteen in order to get it done herself. At fifteen, she'd need a guardian's permission which King Tinger promised to give her provided she managed to beat Askar in a duel.)

Just as Adora put away the last piece of her jewelry and shut the box, Kesi returned, having also taken out her piercings and slipped into more comfortable clothes.

The two girls quickly crawled into bed and snuggled up against each other, both purring away as they drifted off to sleep.

End Notes

Yes, those names for Kesi's parents are, in fact, canonical. Check the Discord server for proof.

There was going to be a scene at the start showing Kesi moving into the High Temple six years after the coup attempt (which is canon) but it didn't really fit in with the rest of the entry so I didn't write it.

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